

How Lunenburg compares: neighbours, peers, look-alikes and destinations

Generated 2026-09-26 from `sources/analyses/towns-like-us.md`. Every figure is recomputed from `sources/data/lunenburg.db` by `scripts/verify_towns_like_us.py`. A printed page outlives the numbers on it: re-run that script before quoting anything here.

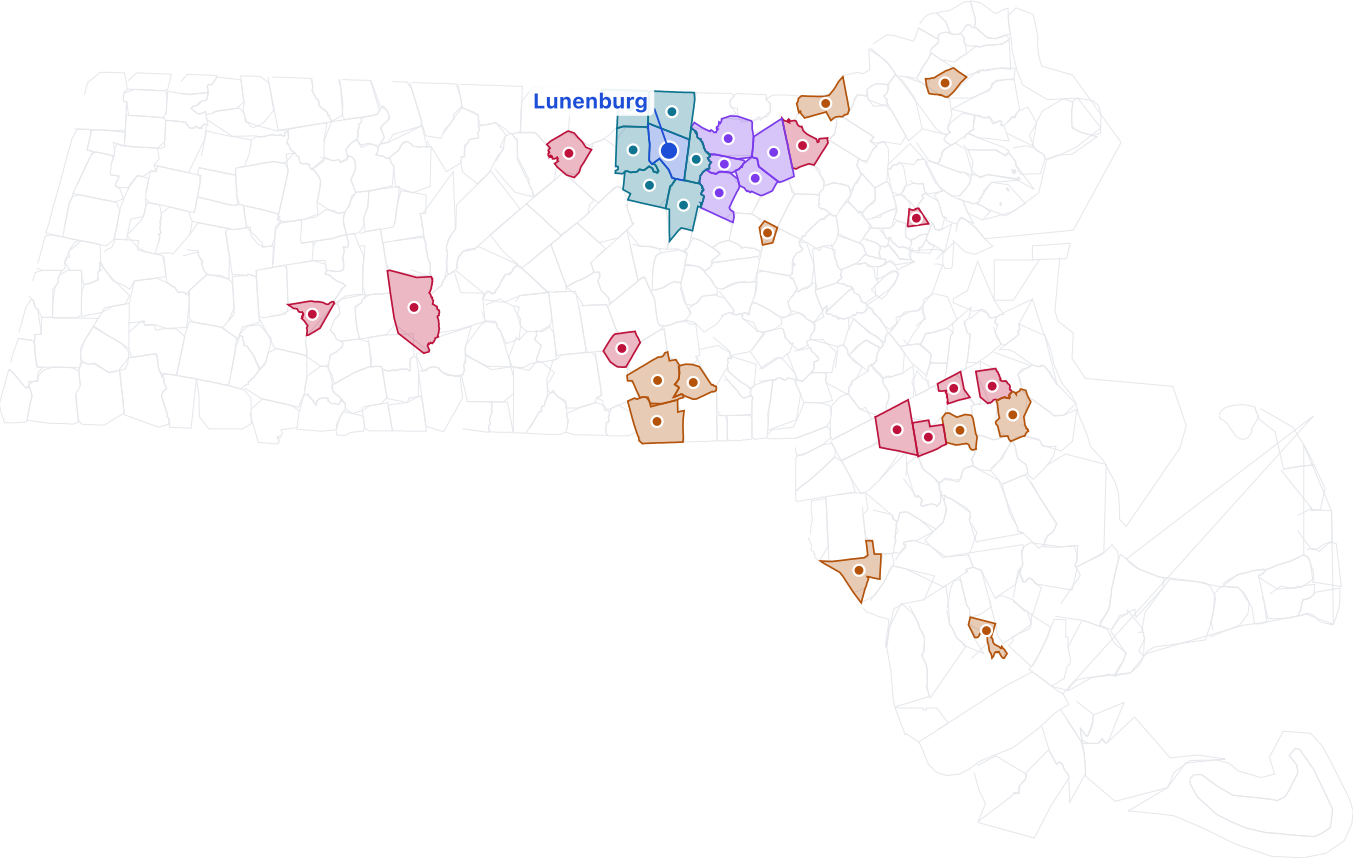
Analysis, generated by `scripts/build_town_comparison.py`. Every figure below is computed from the documents listed at the end; nothing is typed.

Four comparison sets, because they answer four questions. The six towns that share a border. The five this project uses as peers. The towns the math picks out of all 351. And the places Lunenburg children are actually schooled, which is not a peer set at all.

Who Lunenburg is compared with, and where they are

Every Massachusetts town outlined; the 32 compared here are filled, at their Census centroids.

● Lunenburg ● shares a border ● peer (our choice) ● looks like Lunenburg ● behaves like Lunenburg



A map of Massachusetts with every town outlined and the 32 towns this report compares filled and pinned at their Census centroids, coloured by whether they border Lunenburg, are peers this project chose, resemble Lunenburg on structure, or behave like it.

The short version

- **The tax bill tracks home value ($r + 0.91$) and income ($r + 0.92$). New growth: $r - 0.03$.** What a household pays follows what its house is worth and what it earns, not what the town built.
- **Shifting the most the law allows onto commercial saves a \$350,000 home \$224.25 a year.** The town’s assessor recommended against it. A shift moves the bill between classes, not the levy.
- **Of the towns most like Lunenburg, 9 of 10 spend more per pupil and 7 charge less.** Lunenburg is 158th of 161 comparable districts on spending per pupil.
- **On TOTAL school spending growth Lunenburg is 7th of 11: 3.2% a year.** It kept its pupils. The look-alikes lost more, which lifts per-pupil without spending more.

- **0 of 10 — no town is closest to Lunenburg on both what it is and what it does.** 9 towns make the closest 25 on both. Resembling Lunenburg and acting like it are different.
- **Towns that have won more overrides charge higher bills: r +0.61 across 161 towns.** Lunenburg won \$2,010,875 of permanent capacity across 4 wins. A won override never expires.
- **Of 177 Lunenburg children schooled elsewhere, 32 go where one town's taxes pay.** 97 are at Monty Tech, which Lunenburg helps fund; 38 at charters or virtual schools.
- **Ashby has put 60 override questions and won 7. Lunenburg put 10, won 4.** Adjacent towns under the same cost pressure differ 6x in how often they ask.

What the figures count

Two calendars, never mixed. Tax figures are FY2026, the last year the Division of Local Services has a rate for every town: an AVERAGE single-family bill on an AVERAGE single-family assessment, which is not any one house. School figures are SY2025, the last year DESE has published spending: dollars per full-time-equivalent pupil, ALL FUNDS, so state aid and grants are inside it and it is not what the town raises. An override row is a question PUT to a ballot, not a dollar levied.

The towns Lunenburg borders, and the towns it is compared with

Six neighbours, computed from the Census boundary polygons by shared vertices rather than from memory. Five peers, which are this project's own choice — nothing in the town's record names a cohort.

TOWN	ROLE	SCHOOL DISTRICT	AVG BILL FY2026	RANK OF 351	BILL AS % OF INCOME	PER PUPIL SY2025	COMMERCIAL %	OVERRIDES WON/PUT
Lunenburg	Lunenburg	Lunenburg	\$7,444	145	15.55%	\$18,027	8.7%	4 of 10
Ashby	shares a border	North Middlesex	\$6,225	210	15.41%	\$21,528	5.7%	7 of 60
Fitchburg	shares a border	Fitchburg	\$5,189	270	20.32%	\$22,714	18.4%	0 of 1
Lancaster	shares a border	Nashoba	\$9,373	83	20.72%	\$23,109	12.3%	6 of 36
Leominster	shares a border	Leominster	\$6,489	192	18.40%	\$20,182	17.1%	0 of 0
Shirley	shares a border	Ayer Shirley School District	\$6,490	191	16.65%	\$20,428	9.5%	8 of 33
Townsend	shares a border	North Middlesex	\$6,459	194	15.31%	\$21,528	6.9%	8 of 30
Ayer	peer (our choice)	Ayer Shirley School District	\$6,625	185	14.06%	\$20,428	28.4%	3 of 13
Groton	peer (our choice)	Groton-Dunstable	\$11,253	50	12.09%	\$22,664	4.5%	4 of 12
Harvard	peer (our choice)	Harvard	\$14,562	22	16.69%	\$25,565	3.9%	22 of 33
Littleton	peer (our choice)	Littleton	\$10,800	55	14.56%	\$21,367	21.2%	3 of 8
Westford	peer (our choice)	Westford	\$11,171	52	13.74%	\$20,042	9.6%	8 of 23

Every one of the eleven spends more per pupil than Lunenburg's \$18,027. The nearest is Westford at \$20,042, \$2,015 more; the highest is Harvard at \$25,565. Read that beside the enrolment column further down before drawing anything from it — per-pupil spending is a ratio, and these districts have not all kept the same number of children.

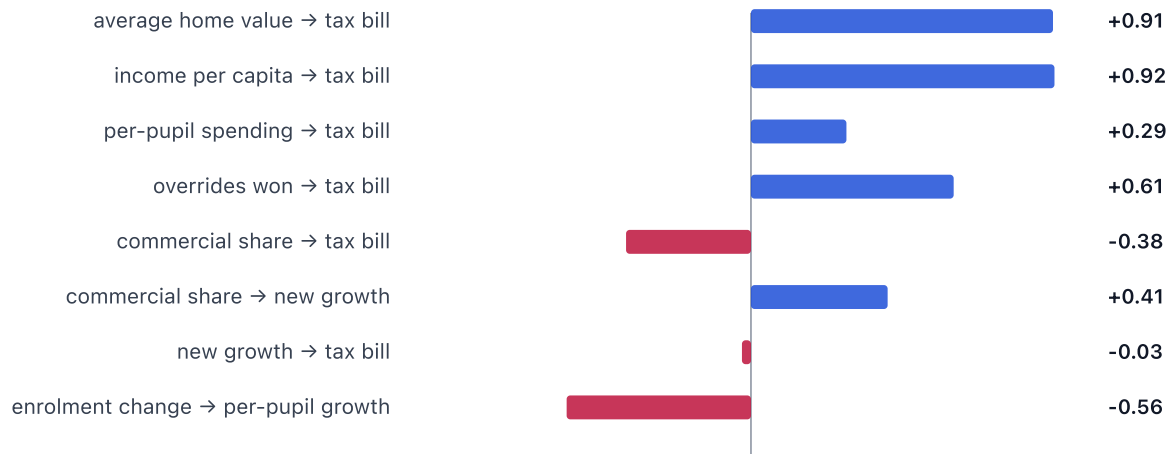
Three of the six neighbours are in a regional district, and two of those share one. Ashby and Townsend are both North Middlesex; Lancaster is in Nashoba; Shirley is in Ayer Shirley with Ayer. So "every bordering town's school district" is not six districts, and a per-pupil figure beside a town is sometimes a figure that town shares with others.

The trend: what actually moves a tax bill

Correlations across the 161 Massachusetts towns that run their own K–12 district — the only shape in which town finance and school finance are the same taxpayer, which is Lunenburg's own shape.

What actually moves a tax bill

Correlation across the 161 towns that run their own K–12 district. Tax figures FY2026, school figures SY2025.
A bar to the right is a positive relationship, to the left negative. Neither says which way causation runs.



Eight correlations drawn as signed bars, across the 161 towns that run their own K–12 district. Average home value and income per capita both track the average tax bill closely; certified new growth against the tax bill is effectively nothing. A bar to the right is a positive relationship and to the left negative; neither says which way causation runs.

RELATIONSHIP	R
average home value → tax bill	+0.91
income per capita → tax bill	+0.92
per-pupil spending → tax bill	+0.29
overrides won → tax bill	+0.61
commercial share → tax bill	-0.38
commercial share → new growth	+0.41
new growth → tax bill	-0.03
enrolment change → per-pupil growth	-0.56

The bill is the house, and the household. Home value and income per capita track the bill almost identically and nothing here separates them — they are largely measuring the same thing. Nothing about the commercial base comes close, and certified new growth, the measure of what a town built, has no relationship to the bill at all. What a commercial base shows up as is new growth itself, which is levy CAPACITY rather than a smaller bill.

What this does not show. Which way any of it runs, and it cannot: this is one year read across many towns. A town with expensive houses can afford a higher bill and also chooses one. What would settle the question for Lunenburg specifically is not a comparison at all — it is the town’s own levy history against its own new growth, which is on what growth would have to look like.

THE TOWN HAS ALREADY PRICED THIS, FOR THIS TOWN

Lunenburg levies a **single tax rate** and decides every November what share of the levy each class of property bears. At the Select Board’s tax classification hearing on 25 November 2025 the Principal Assessor priced the maximum shift onto commercial, industrial and personal property. The minute:

“The estimated Fiscal Year 2026 single tax rate was projected at \$14.39 per thousand” “At the maximum allowable CIP shift of 1.50, the residential tax rate would decrease to \$13.70 per thousand while the commercial tax rate would rise to \$21.58 per thousand” “a savings of only \$224.25 for a \$350,000 residential property” “a tax increase of approximately \$2,336.75 for a comparable commercial property” — Select Board minutes, 25 November 2025 (our copy, the town’s)

Her arithmetic reconciles to the state’s file. The same minute states an average single-family bill of \$7,443.89 on an average value of \$517,296; the Division of Local Services publishes \$7,444 on \$517,296 for the same year. Two independent records of the same two quantities, agreeing to the cent — which is what makes the rest of the analysis worth repeating, because the split-rate figures themselves are hers and we have not recomputed them.

She recommended against a split rate, noting that Lunenburg’s commercial share is under a tenth of the base — this report computes 8.7% for FY2026. **A shift moves the bill between classes. It does not reduce the levy**, which is set before any of this and is what the correlation above is really saying.

The towns the math says look like Lunenburg

Two cohorts over the same 161 towns. **Structural** matches on eight things a town does not decide: how many children, how many are low income, English learners or have disabilities, how many are placed out of district, the average house, income per capita, and the commercial share of the base. **Behavioural** matches on nine things

it does: the bill, the bill as a share of income, per-pupil spending, override questions put and won, and the trend in the bill, in spending and in enrolment.

Spending and bills are deliberately absent from the structural cohort. A cohort matched on per-pupil spending cannot then be asked whether Lunenburg spends like its cohort — the answer would have been assumed.

TOWN	COHORT	DISTANCE	AVG BILL FY2026	PER PUPIL SY2025	COMMERCIAL %	OVERRIDES WON/PUT	ENROLMENT SINCE SY2011
Lunenburg	Lunenburg	—	\$7,444	\$18,027	8.7%	4 of 10	-5.1%
Swansea	looks like Lunenburg	0.391	\$5,623	\$20,614	11.7%	0 of 1	-5.7%
Douglas	looks like Lunenburg	0.450	\$6,298	\$21,491	14.4%	4 of 12	-34.4%
Georgetown	looks like Lunenburg	0.465	\$10,314	\$21,277	8.8%	6 of 19	-28.0%
Northbridge	looks like Lunenburg	0.471	\$5,922	\$19,568	11.6%	2 of 4	-23.2%
Fairhaven	looks like Lunenburg	0.481	\$4,374	\$19,065	13.4%	0 of 3	-13.2%
East Bridgewater	looks like Lunenburg	0.498	\$7,410	\$19,412	12.0%	0 of 0	-12.5%
Maynard	looks like Lunenburg	0.499	\$10,081	\$26,738	9.6%	6 of 19	-5.3%
Pembroke	looks like Lunenburg	0.503	\$7,521	\$21,722	11.6%	1 of 4	-28.5%
Dracut	looks like Lunenburg	0.529	\$5,737	\$17,188	7.8%	0 of 13	-7.6%
Sutton	looks like Lunenburg	0.541	\$7,247	\$21,011	15.1%	2 of 3	-18.2%
Auburn	behaves like Lunenburg	0.507	\$6,307	\$18,747	23.7%	2 of 6	+4.2%
Hanover	behaves like Lunenburg	0.577	\$10,149	\$18,856	15.0%	3 of 4	-4.9%
Melrose	behaves like Lunenburg	0.582	\$9,787	\$17,315	5.0%	3 of 11	+3.9%
Easton	behaves like Lunenburg	0.589	\$9,441	\$19,190	11.2%	3 of 17	-12.1%
Belchertown	behaves like Lunenburg	0.602	\$6,622	\$19,035	6.3%	4 of 14	-18.9%
Chelmsford	behaves like Lunenburg	0.626	\$9,219	\$19,876	14.7%	2 of 8	-6.7%
Easthampton	behaves like Lunenburg	0.676	\$5,562	\$20,985	12.1%	4 of 14	-13.5%
West Bridgewater	behaves like Lunenburg	0.685	\$7,433	\$18,633	29.3%	1 of 5	+6.1%
Abington	behaves like Lunenburg	0.691	\$7,536	\$19,624	10.5%	3 of 6	+6.9%
Gardner	behaves like Lunenburg	0.714	\$5,052	\$18,939	15.1%	0 of 6	-1.2%

No town appears in both closest-ten lists. Widen each to twenty-five and 9 do: Northbridge, Dracut, Tyngsborough, Grafton, Abington, West Boylston, Easton, Ashland, Belchertown.

What this does not show. That either cohort is the right one. A distance is a statement about these measures given EQUAL WEIGHT and nothing more, and no weighting between dollars, percentages and counts is defensible enough to prefer. What the empty intersection does establish is that "who is like us" has no single answer.

And the grade-span test is a published fact, not a proxy. An earlier version of this cohort admitted any district reporting a grade-10 MCAS score, and DESE reports those by district of RESIDENCE — so an elementary district whose teenagers attend a regional high school came third on structural similarity. Membership now reads `grades_served` off DESE’s school-level file: does this district operate a school reaching grade 12.

A PER-PUPIL FIGURE YOU MAY HAVE HEARD, WHICH IS NOT THIS ONE

Monty Tech’s superintendent told the Finance Committee on 6 March 2025 that “The foundational budget per pupil spent is \$20,827.” That is a different school and a different quantity: a **foundation budget** is a Chapter 70 formula output — the state’s model of what an adequate education costs — and it is thousands of dollars away from what any district actually spends. Every per-pupil figure in this report is SPENDING, all funds, reported after the year closed. (the minute)

Where Lunenburg children are actually schooled

Not a peer set. This is enrolment: where children who live in Lunenburg went in FY2026, and what kind of thing each place is — because a tax bill can only be set beside a district that one town’s taxpayers fund.

DESTINATION	CHILDREN	WHAT FUNDS IT
Lunenburg	1,553	Lunenburg's own schools
Montachusett Regional Vocational Technical	97	an assessment Lunenburg itself pays, as a member town
Leominster	18	one town's taxpayers
Francis W. Parker Charter Essential (District)	15	no single town — a charter or Commonwealth virtual school
Fitchburg	8	one town's taxpayers
Greater Commonwealth Virtual District	8	no single town — a charter or Commonwealth virtual school
TEC Connections Academy Commonwealth Virtual School District	8	no single town — a charter or Commonwealth virtual school
Sizer School: A North Central Charter Essential (District)	7	no single town — a charter or Commonwealth virtual school
Nashoba	4	assessments on several member towns, with different bills
Harvard	3	one town's taxpayers
Gardner	2	one town's taxpayers
Ayer Shirley School District	2	assessments on several member towns, with different bills
Littleton	1	one town's taxpayers
Berlin-Boylston	1	assessments on several member towns, with different bills
Groton-Dunstable	1	assessments on several member towns, with different bills
North Middlesex	1	assessments on several member towns, with different bills
Ralph C Mahar	1	assessments on several member towns, with different bills

What this does not show. What any of it costs. A count of children is not a tuition, a charter assessment or a share of a regional assessment — and nothing here says which fund pays. Nor why a family chose a destination: the file records an enrolment and nothing else.

Who this was read for

`notes/process/PERSONAS.md` carries six readers and one test each, every concern quoted from a real public meeting. The review of this report is recorded there. Two of its findings are in the report above and would not have been: the Principal Assessor had already priced the commercial shift for this town, and the town has never published a list of comparable communities — which makes every “compared with similar towns” claim, including this one, rest on a set nobody has agreed.

The sources

- **Massachusetts DOR, Division of Local Services** — Average single-family tax bill, value, parcels, income per capita and rank, all 351 municipalities, FY1988 onward.

`sources/state-dls/AvgSingleFamTaxBill-2026-09-26-5d7664b92f9f.xlsx` · sha256 `5d7664b92f9f99e2` Publisher's address: https://dls-gw.dor.state.ma.us/reports/rdPage.aspx?rdReport=AverageSingleTaxBill.SingleFamTaxBill_wRange&rdReportFormat=NativeExcel&rdExportTableID=tblSinglefamtaxbill&rdExportFilename=AvgSingleFamTa

- **Massachusetts DOR, Division of Local Services** — Assessed value by class, so the commercial-industrial-personal share is the state's certified figure rather than ours.

`sources/state-dls/assessedvalues-2026-09-26-272171893ca3.xlsx` · sha256 `272171893ca3b05a` Publisher's address: <https://dls-gateway.dor.state.ma.us/reports/rdPage.aspx?rdReport=PropertyTaxInformation.AssessedValuesbyClass.assessedvaluesbyclass&rdReportFormat=NativeExcel&rdExportTableID=tblassessedvalues&rdExportFilename=PropertyTaxInformation.AssessedValuesbyClass.assessedvaluesbyclass>

- **Massachusetts DOR, Division of Local Services** — New growth certified onto the levy limit each year, and the prior year's limit it is measured against.

`sources/state-dls/new_growth-2026-09-26-3b8980b0efc3.xlsx` · sha256 `3b8980b0efc38de6` Publisher's address: https://dls-gw.dor.state.ma.us/reports/rdPage.aspx?rdReport=NewGrowth.NewGrowth_dash_v2_test&rdReportFormat=NativeExcel&rdExportTableID=tblNewGrowth&rdExportFilename=new_growth&rdShowGridline

- **Massachusetts DOR, Division of Local Services** — Every Proposition 2½ override and override put to a town, with the date, the tallies and the result.

`sources/state-dls/OverrideOverrideVotes.xlsx` · sha256 `8fa6e1fbcf9771b1`

- **Massachusetts DESE** — Per-pupil expenditure by category, enrolment in and out of district, and student demographics, for every district in the state.

`sources/state-dese/er3w-dyti.json` · sha256 `12a853ce1295588b` Publisher's address: <https://educationtocareer.data.mass.gov/resource/er3w-dyti.json>

- **Massachusetts DESE** — Which grades each school actually serves — the published fact that decides whether a district runs a high school.

`sources/state-dese/i5up-aez6-grades-served.json` · sha256 162fa23800a01de9 Publisher's address: <https://educationtocareer.data.mass.gov/resource/i5up-aez6.json>

- **Town of Lunenburg, Select Board** — The Principal Assessor's split-rate analysis: the single rate, the average bill, and what the largest shift the statute allows onto commercial property would be worth. Quoted rather than paraphrased, and re-read on every build.

`sources/meetings/text/select-board/2025-11-25-minutes-7534.txt` · sha256 db42e5e9e4913d1c Publisher's address: https://www.lunenburgma.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Minutes/_11252025-7534

- **US Census Bureau, TIGERweb** — Town boundaries and centroids: which towns share a border with Lunenburg, and where each one is on the map.

`sources/state-census/tigerweb-cousub-massachusetts.json` · sha256 350e59f82599e345 Publisher's address: https://tigerweb.geo.census.gov/arcgis/rest/services/TIGERweb/Places_CouSub_ConCity_SubMCD/MapServer/1/query

What this report cannot establish

- Whose comparison set is right. The six neighbours are computed from boundary polygons and are a fact; the five peers are OUR choice, and nothing in the town's own record names a cohort of comparable communities for tax purposes. The twins are a distance in a space we chose the axes of.
- What any destination costs. A count of children enrolled somewhere is not a tuition, an assessment or a share of one, and nothing here says which fund pays for any of it.
- The tax burden behind a regional district. Nashoba, North Middlesex, Ayer Shirley and Montachusett are funded by assessments on member towns with different bills, and no dataset here holds the membership lists or the apportionment, so no single bill can stand for any of them.
- Whether a town spending more per pupil educates a child better. Per-pupil spending is an input. Nothing in this report is an outcome measure.
- Which way any correlation runs. Every figure here is a cross-section of one year across many towns, which cannot separate a town choosing a higher bill from a town able to afford one.

Three of these are registered in `sources/data/money-gaps.csv` and appear on what we cannot answer, each with the one document that would close it: the town's own list of comparable communities, the apportionment behind each regional district's assessment, and what Lunenburg pays per child for each destination outside its schools.